

The Washington Post

Prices may vary in areas outside metropolitan Washington.

SU V1 V2 V3 V4



Partly sunny 90/69 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 94/71 B20

Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, APRIL 14, 2026 • \$4

Embattled members leaving Congress

Reps. Swalwell, Gonzales choose to leave ahead of possible expulsion

BY MARIANA ALFARO
AND AMY B WANG

Reps. Eric Swalwell (D-California) and Tony Gonzales (R-Texas) separately announced plans to depart from Congress on Monday ahead of possible expulsion votes related to allegations of sexual misconduct.

Swalwell, who has vehemently denied an accusation of sexual assault but acknowledged some past “mistakes in judgment,” said he would resign because it was wrong “for my constituents to have me distracted from my duties.”

“I will fight the serious, false allegation made against me,” he said in a statement. “However, I must take responsibility and ownership for the mistakes I did make.”

Shortly afterward, Gonzales released a statement saying he would “file my retirement from office” on Tuesday.

“There is a season for everything and God has a plan for us all,” said Gonzales, who has acknowledged an affair with a former member of his staff, a violation of House rules.

The departures of Swalwell and Gonzales — one Democrat and one Republican — would mean the Republicans’ narrow majority in the House remains unchanged if they leave the chamber at the same time.

Swalwell faces accusations of sexual assault from a former staffer, first reported by the San

SEE SWALWELL ON A7

‘DOGE’ felt more like a club’ than an agency

Depositions reveal Musk and his charges worked with little oversight

BY MERYL KORNFIELD

Members of the U.S. DOGE Service spoke regularly over Signal, the encrypted chat service that can auto-delete messages. They were informally recruited by people they knew. And other government employees didn’t know who was “DOGE.”

When DOGE members were deposed in January as part of a lawsuit over cuts to grants awarded to the National Endowment for the Humanities, they described a vague network of similarly minded technologists and lawyers who had been tasked with a vast mandate to reduce federal spending. They also described a lack of structure that allowed them to operate with little oversight or understanding of what others might be doing.

“DOGE felt more like a club,” Justin Fox, an investment banker turned DOGE staffer, told attorneys in one of the video depositions released last month.

A year after Elon Musk brought in a cohort of allies from Silicon Valley to remake the government,

SEE DOGE ON A4

“I thought it was me as a doctor.”

President Trump, on sharing what appeared to be an AI-generated image on social media that triggered immediate backlash



SALWAN GEORGES/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

President Donald Trump speaks on Monday after issuing a verbal attack on the pope and drawing a rare rebuke from the religious right.

President’s post appears to depict him as Jesus

BY NATALIE ALLISON

President Donald Trump’s posting of an image that appeared to depict him as Jesus drew rare criticism from the religious right, prompting allegations of blasphemy and calls for him to take down the post before it was deleted.

Shortly after posting a screed against Pope Leo XIV on Sunday night as he returned to Washington from Florida, Trump shared

Trump draws criticism, accusations of blasphemy, before image is deleted

an image that appeared to be AI-generated in the style of a painting, depicting him in a long white robe with a red cloak draped around his shoulders. In one hand was an orb glowing

with light; Trump’s other hand rested on the forehead of a man in what resembled a hospital bed — light beaming from the man’s head as Trump appeared to pray for his healing. Patriotic symbols including an eagle, fireworks and the Statue of Liberty filled the frame.

Unlike the post criticizing Leo, whom Trump later said he didn’t like and is too “liberal,” the image evoking Jesus drew swift criticism from some evangelical

Christians and conservative Catholics who have otherwise expressed near constant support for Trump’s decisions.

“I don’t know if the President thought he was being funny or if he is under the influence of some substance or what possible explanation he could have for this OUTRAGEOUS blasphemy,”

SEE TRUMP ON A13

Philip Kennicott: The sloppy symbolism of the AI image. A13

War in Middle East dims GOP’s midterm prospects

BY HANNAH KNOWLES

Republicans always expected the 2026 elections would be tough. Then the U.S. went to war with Iran.

Gas prices — one of President Donald Trump’s favorite metrics — shot up, fanning economic anxiety just as Republicans were hoping to focus on Americans’ tax breaks and refunds. Analysts say

Fallout threatens to undercut Republicans’ economic pitch to voters

costs could stay elevated well into the year even if the war ends soon. “Consumer Sentiment Drops to LOWEST ON RECORD,” a Fri-

day email from the Democratic National Committee blared.

If Republicans lose one or both chambers of Congress in November, they may point to this period as a crossroads when an already daunting midterm year got harder. The fallout of the war threatens to undercut the GOP economic pitch for months, and Trump is struggling to control the conflict, alarming politicians in both par-

ties with his recent social media threat to wipe out “a whole civilization” in Iran.

The president has suggested the war could wind down soon, and Republicans have cast it as a temporary disruption. But as the conflict enters its seventh week — with the United States still trying to reopen a key shipping route for oil — the ripple effects could

SEE GOP ON A6



MARTON MONUS/REUTERS

Celebrating change in Hungary

People gather in Budapest on Monday after Peter Magyar and the opposition Tisza Party beat Hungarian premier Viktor Orban, an ally of President Donald Trump, in parliamentary elections Sunday. **Story, A8**

Even with wealth, some in U.S. feel middle class

Number of millionaires in U.S. is at all-time high, but nest eggs feel lighter

BY ABHA BHATTARAI,
RACHEL LERMAN
AND FEDERICA COCCO

There are more American millionaires than ever before, but many of them don’t feel rich.

Average net worth in the United States is over \$1 million per household, Federal Reserve data shows, with roughly 1 in 6 families surpassing the seven-figure mark.

Yet, many of the country’s newest millionaires say that even with such wealth, they still feel undeniably middle-class. In many parts of the country, \$1 million has become a starting point for the American Dream. The average entry-level homes cost \$1 million or

more in more than 200 U.S. cities — including parts of Kansas, Minnesota and Georgia — according to a recent analysis by Zillow.

“It’s a milestone, but having a million dollars doesn’t mean you’re super wealthy anymore,” said Nathan Winklepleck, 36, a financial adviser with Donaldson Capital Management near Indianapolis who recently passed the millionaire threshold with his wife. “It’s not quite what it used to be in terms of rarefied status.”

Rising costs have chipped away at the value of \$1 million, according to Bureau of Labor Statistics data. That amount stretches about as far as \$480,000 did 30 years ago.

Or put another way, \$2.1 million today is equivalent to what \$1 million was about 30 years ago — which helps explain why there are so many more millionaires than there were a generation or two ago.

SEE MILLIONAIRES ON A16

IN THE NEWS

EPA delays approvals of chemicals The Trump administration’s rush to roll back environmental rules hit a MAHA wall of pushback from GOP-allied groups. **A3**

Trump vs. Leo Veteran church observers say an open war of words between a pope and a U.S. president is unprecedented. **A12**

THE NATION
The White House says it’s boosting affordability through physician reform. **A3**
New York’s mayor is moving ahead with plans to open five city-run grocery stores. **A5**

THE WORLD
Hungary’s neighbors in Europe also celebrated Viktor Orban’s defeat in his reelection bid. **A9**
Orban’s defeat shows the limits of Trump’s influence abroad. **A9**

THE ECONOMY
As New Yorkers splurge, their doormen are struggling to make ends meet, and 34,000 of them have threatened to strike over stagnant wages in an increasingly testy battle over who can afford to live and work in New York. **A15**

STYLE
Renderings for the president’s planned “triumphal arch” reek of racism. **B1**

SPORTS
Alex Ovechkin, Washington’s greatest athlete this century, could play his last game for the Capitals on Tuesday. **B7**

THE REGION
Prekindergarten applications in D.C. have plunged this year amid deportation fears and federal layoffs. **B13**
The area will feel the effects of a summerlike heat wave that will hit the East this week and worsen drought conditions. **B13**

BUSINESS NEWS.....A15
COMICS.....B4
OBITUARIES.....B16
OPINION PAGES.....A17
TELEVISION.....B6
WORLD NEWS.....A8

CONTENT © 2026
The Washington Post
Year 149, No. 54551

